Exploring Collaboration between a Language and a Non-Language Agent

Harini S I[1*], Somesh Singh[1,2,3*], Yaman K Singla[1], Rajiv Ratn Shah[2], David Doermann[3], Balaji Krishnamurthy[1]

[1]Adobe [2]IIIT-Delhi [3]SUNY at Buffalo [*]Equal contribution

EMNLP2026 BUDAPEST

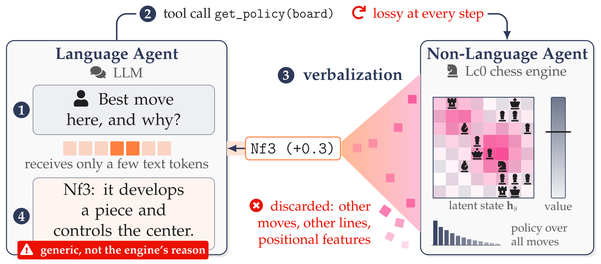
Motivation

How can an LLM effectively collaborate with non-language agents?

- LLMs have become general purpose orchestrators that can solve complex domain specific tasks by coordinating with tools and domain expert subagents.
- However, in many important domains such as robotics and game playing, the strongest available agents are **not language models**. Their expertise lives in rich internal representations (e.g. AlphaZero, RT-1).
- We study this collaboration using **chess** as a controlled environment owing to strong open engines (Lc0), public datasets, and real world tasks.

Verbalization Is Lossy

- Current methods call the agent as a tool and **verbalize** its output into text. However, this collapses the rich internal representation, into a few text tokens. We show the first quantification of this **Verbalization Debt**.



Our Approach

- A **language agent** (Qwen3 LLM) collaborates with a frozen **non-language agent** (Lc0-BT4 chess engine) and can update its state dynamically through verbalized **actions**.
- **Latent state internalization:** the engine's internal state is directly projected and concatenated into the LLM's Chain of Thought as **state tokens**, instead of being verbalized.
- The LLM is trained with **reinforcement learning** to reason over **language**, **action** and **state** tokens. We call the resulting model **Llamia**.

Latent State Internalization

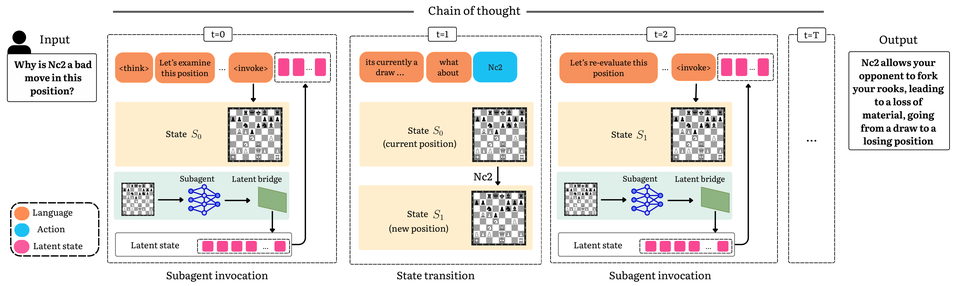
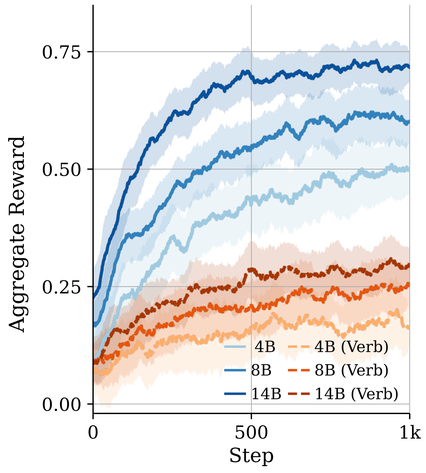


Illustration of internalized CoT. The LLM reasons in **language**, calls the engine on the current board state, plays an **action** that changes the board. The LatentBridge projects Lc0 (subagent)'s internal board representations or **states** into the LLM's CoT at each invokation

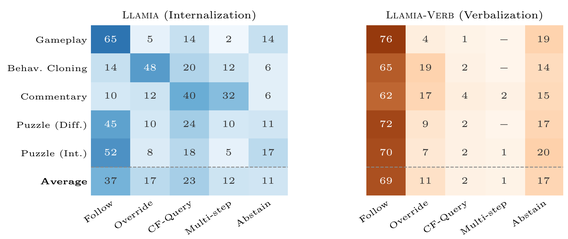
- **Projection.** Lc0's hidden state $\mathbf{h}_s$ (layer 14 of 15) is mapped by a 3-layer MLP, the **Latent-Bridge**, to k=32 **state tokens** in the LLM's embedding space: $\mathbf{z}_s = H_\varphi(\mathbf{h}_s)$.
- **Dynamic invocation.** Inside its chain of thought, the LLM can repeatedly decide **when** to call the subagent and execute **actions** that update the board to counterfactual states, and call `get_policy` on any position. Each call re-encodes the current state, so the LLM always reasons over the position it is analyzing.

Training with Reinforcement Learning

- **Stage 1: projector alignment.** We follow LLaVA style two stage training, training only the LatentBridge on large scale synthetic state–value pairs.
- **Stage 2: reinforcement learning.** We post-train the LLM and LatentBridge jointly with **DAPO** on six of LLAMIA-Bench tasks. **State tokens** are masked from the policy gradient. The engine stays frozen in both stages.
- **Verbalization Baseline:** We also train Llamia-Verb replacing the state tokens with verbalized summaries (best moves, evaluation, position)



Emergent collaboration strategies

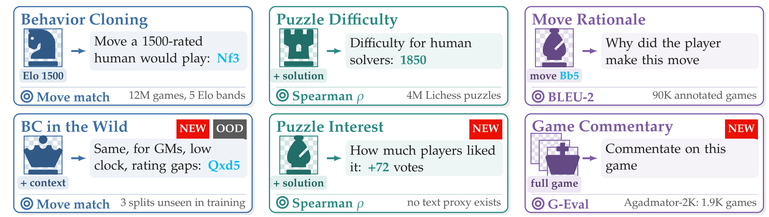


Strategy share (%) over 500 episodes per task (GPT-4o judge, κ=0.78). Left: Llamia. Right: Llamia-Verb.

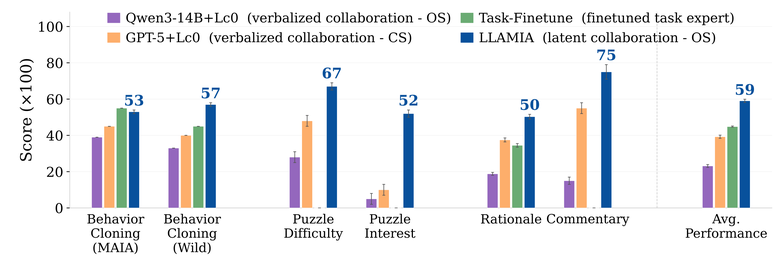
- Llamia **adapts its strategy to the task**: engine-follow for gameplay, consult-then-override for behavior cloning, counterfactual queries for commentary.
- Llamia-Verb **collapses to engine-follow** on every task (62–76%).
- **Cost neutral:** fewer engine calls (1.9 vs. 2.9 per query).

Llamia-Bench

- We introduce **LLAMIA-Bench** a compilation of six popular chess tasks including Behavior Cloning, Move/Game Commentary Generation, and Puzzle Understanding including three new datasets
- None of these tasks can be solved by pretrained LLMs or Engines alone.

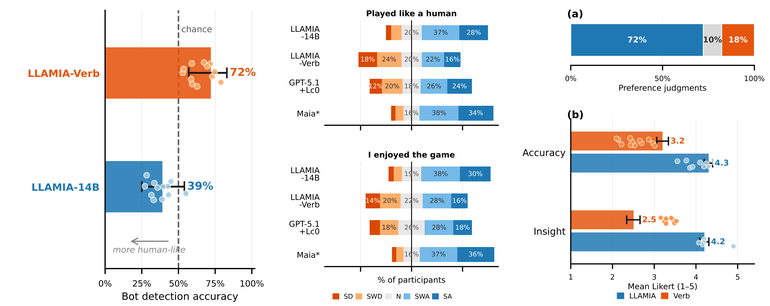


Results



- A single Llamia-14B model is best on all six tasks, across all tasks and sizes, ahead of GPT-5 with the same engine as a tool, and even existing state of the art task-specific finetuned models.
- **Beyond chess.** On Go with KataGo, the same method is ~10 points above the text-based control.

Human study



n=12 skilled players (all rated ≥1700). Left: players spot Llamia as a bot in only 39% of games (below chance; Llamia-Verb: 72%). Middle: post-game ratings put Llamia on par with Maia* for human-likeness. Right: 72% of commentary judgments prefer Llamia.